

I. DIE GESCHICHTE DER MENNONITEN BRÜDER GEMEINDE - A. H. Unruh
Freeman Heritage Archives - pp 440-441 - Translation from the German:

In the year 1876 individual members of the Mennonite Brethren Church out of Russia met in Turner County, in what is known today as South Dakota, and found among the Germans various signs of earnest questions regarding salvation, brought about mainly through the "Evangelical Church". Through the Baptist ministers the question of baptism came to the foreground. In May 1877 the individual members of the Mennonite Brethren Church had been augmented to the extent that they had their own services and elected Br. Corn. Günther as leader and Bro. David Funk as assistant. Soon eight persons, then two, were baptized. Upon the request of Brothers Günther and Funk a council was elected, namely Henry Adrian and Is. Loewen. The first named received the majority of the votes. As such he became in 1878 the leader over a number of stations. In 1881 two more brethren were elected as fellow-workers. By this time the work was stretched over 35 miles. The ordination of Brother Adrian was officiated Oct. 30, 1881 by Br. A. Schellenberg. After a while, during which there were good results, a deep pain was experienced when 31 members left to join the Adventists. But again there were members added. In Nov. 1885 Bro. Voth was installed as teacher, but in 1886 it looked as though the Church would fold up when 79 members went over to the Adventists. (This was perhaps due to poor instruction). However, after several ~~years~~ baptisms the Church again numbered 80 members on four stations: Brotherfield, Wittenburg, Rosefield and Emmanuels Creek...

* See next page for further excerpt from the above historical source

II. THE MENNONITE ENCYCLOPEDIA - VOL. III - Freeman Heritage Library Archives

p. 598 - "An M.B. Congregation began in Turner County, South Dakota, in 1876, which today is known as the Dolton or Silver Lake M.B. Church. Several other groups of M.B. Members settled in other parts of South Dakota and began services, but these have not materialized into permanent congregations."

p. 599 - "On October 8-20, 1879, representatives from M.B. Churches in Kansas, Nebraska, Minnesota and South Dakota met at Henderson, Nebraska, and organized a conference. The purpose for organizing was to build up the churches in their spiritual life, to give united expression to the position the Church holds on various points, and to work unitedly in the various church activities. Such a general conference was held annually 1879-1909, and since then triennially."

III. TURNER COUNTY PIONEER HISTORY - Parker City Library

p. 60 - "The settlement of Brothersfield began in 1874. Tobias Unruh and family came from Russia Aug. 1, 1873. They moved to what is now Brothersfield Township, April 16, 1874. Others who came the same year were Henry Adrian, Peter Engbrecht, John Boese, Diedrich Loewen ... Henry and Tobias Kunkle and the Brandts came in 1875."

p. 61 - "The first services were held in homes. The first denomination to hold services was the Evangelical. The first church was built on John John's quarter. It was a M. B. Church. Cornelius Guenther was the first pastor."

CENTER FOR MB STUDIES
TABOR COLLEGE
HILLSBORO, KS 67063-1799

IV. A CENTURY OF MENNONITES IN DAKOTA - John D. Unruh

p. 55 - "In the Silver Lake area the first services were held in homes and were begun in 1886. It was not until 1891 that the first church building was erected. Reverend Henry Unruh was elected the first minister in this group in 1889. Jacob P. Adrian, son of elder Jacob J. Adrian, was one of the first deacons. The church had approximately seventy-five members."

* From former page, a continuation of excerpts of the history by Dr. A. H. Unruh, pp. 440-441 -

In Brothersfield, the Brethren Adrian, Peter and Johann Boese (the last two ordained in 1901) worked in great blessing, but under great difficulties, because they were surrounded by English-speaking neighbors, and because of schools and other problems. As a result the small group began to move away, until in 1902 Elder Adrian also moved to Kansas... in 1913 all had moved away. The church building had been sold the year before...

The Station Rosenfeld, 16 miles from Parker, was at its height in 1890, but on May 25, 1890, the neighboring Station of Silverlake received a large number of Believers. Consequently it became the main station for that area...

~~The~~ Of the now (1924)-named Dolton Church, Silverlake is the source. Br. H.P. Unruh, voted as Preacher, helped during all the years until he moved to California in 1909, but returned later. In 1909 Br. Bestvater was ordained as Preacher and P. Fast as Deacon... In 1911 Bestvaters moved away, and in 1913 Br. J.J. Adrian was voted as Preacher. Four years later he was ordained by Br. Voth, as was also Br. P. Fast, who received the leadership.

*From the History of the M.B. Church, by J. A. Toews, p. 141 (1975 Edition)
The Congregation was organized in 1878 near Parker, S. D.
Later the center shifted west to Silver Lake.*

CENTER FOR MB STUDIES
TABOR COLLEGE
HILLSBORO, KS 67063-1799